

IN THE SUPREME COURT OF BANGLADESH
HIGH COURT DIVISION
(CRIMINAL APPELLATE JURISDICTION)

Present:
Mr. Justice Mamnoon Rahman

Criminal Appeal No. 6718 of 2015

Md. Aminur Islam

.....Convict-appellant

-VERSUS-

The State and another

..... Respondents

None appears

..... For the appellant

Mr. Mohammad Taifoor Kabir, DAG with

Mr. Md. Lokman Hossain, AAG

Mr. Md. Hatem Ali, AAG

..... For the respondent No. 1

Mr. Md. Najmul Huda, Advocate

..... For the respondent No. 2

Judgment on 20th May, 2024

In the instant appeal, the convict-appellant has challenged the legality of the judgment and order of conviction and sentence dated 30.04.2015 passed by the learned Sessions Judge Court, Gaibandha in Sessions Case No. 08 of 2015 arising out of C.R. Case No. 258 of 2014 convicting the convict-appellant under section 138 of the Negotiable Instruments Act, 1881 and sentencing him to suffer simple imprisonment for a period of 6(six) months and to pay fine of Tk. 4,00,000/-.

Md. Abu Bakkar Siddique is the Complainant-Respondent No. 2.

None appeared for the convict-appellant when the appeal is called on for hearing.

Mr. Md. Najmul Huda, learned Advocate appearing for the complainant-respondent No. 2, submits that the charge brought against the convict-appellant under section 138 of the Negotiable Instruments Act, 1881 (in short, 'the Act, 1881') has been proved beyond reasonable doubt and therefore, the appeal is liable to be dismissed.

I have heard the learned counsel of the complainant-respondent no. 2, perused the petition of appeal of the convict-appellant and the materials on record.

It appears from the petition of complaint, the deposition of PW1(complainant) and PW 2 as well as the documentary evidences that the convict-appellant issued cheque in question in favour of the complainant-respondent on 11.03.2014 for repayment of outstanding amount of Tk. 2,00,000/- which he took from the complainant. The value of the cheque is Tk. 2,00,000/-. It was dishonoured by the bank concerned on 20.03.2014 and 19.5.2014 respectively. The complainant sent the statutory legal notice to the convict-appellant on 27.05.2014. The value of the cheque was not paid to the complainant. The case was filed on 30.06.2014. P.W.1 and P.W. 2 proved the prosecution case.

I have no hesitation to hold that the complainant-respondent has proved compliance of the procedure laid down in section 138 of

the Act, 1881 in filing the case. The case was filed within one month of the date on which the cause of action had arisen under clause (c) of the proviso to section 138. The complainant also proved the consideration against which the cheque was drawn and that he is the holder of the cheque in due course. Hence, in my view, the impugned judgment and order of conviction does not suffer from any illegality or infirmity. The Trial Court correctly found the appellant guilty of the charge.

Section 138 of the Act, 1881 provides that the offence of dishonour of cheque is punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to 1 (one) year, or with fine which may extend to thrice the amount of the cheque, or with both. Sub-section (2) of Section 138 provides, “*Where any fine is realised under sub-section (1), any amount up to the face value of the cheque as far as is covered by the fine realised shall be paid to the holder*”. Thus, the criminal proceeding under section 138 serves two purposes: firstly, to punish the offender and secondly, to recover the value of the cheque. The object of adding sub-section (2) to section 138 is to alleviate the grievance of the complainant. In the instant case, the value of the dishonoured cheque is Tk. 2,00,000/- whereas the convict-appellant was fined Tk. 4,00,000/- to be given to the complainant which requires interference. Hence, the sentence of fine is modified to the value of the dishonoured cheque i.e., Tk. 2,00,000/- (two lac).

Now, I turn to the sentence of imprisonment. There can be no dispute in so far as the sentence of imprisonment is concerned that it should commensurate with the gravity of the offence. Court has to deal with the offenders by imposing proper sentence by taking into consideration the facts and circumstances of each case. It is not only the rights of the offenders which are required to be looked into at the time of the imposition of sentence, but also of the victims of the crime and society at large, also by considering the object sought to be achieved by the particular legislation. Considering the facts and circumstances of the case and the object of the law, I am of the view that the sentence of imprisonment would be a harsh sentence having no penal objective to be achieved. Hence, the sentence of imprisonment is set aside.

I note that the trial court has not passed any default order *i.e.*, imprisonment in default of payment of the fine. When an offender is sentenced to fine only, the Court has the power to make a default order under Section 388 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (in short the 'Cr.P.C.'). Section 423(1)(d) of the Cr.P.C. empowers the Appellate Court to pass any consequential or incidental order that may be 'just and proper'. Since, this Court has already set aside the sentence of imprisonment, it would be just and proper to pass a default order.

In view of the foregoing discussions, the order of this Court is as follows:

The conviction of the appellant under section 138 of the Act, 1881 is upheld, but the sentence is modified. The sentence of 06(six) months simple imprisonment is set aside. The sentence of fine of Tk. 4,00,000/- (four lac) is modified to Tk. 2,00,000/- (two lac) which is equivalent to the value of the dishonoured cheque. The convict-appellant has already deposited Tk. 1,00,000/- (one lac) in the Trial Court before filing the appeal. The Trial Court is directed to give the said deposited amount to the tune of Tk. 1,00,000/- (one lac) to the complainant-respondent No.2 forthwith. The convict-appellant is directed to pay the remaining portion of the value of the dishonoured cheque *i.e.*, Tk. 1,00,000/- (one lac) to the complainant-respondent No. 3 within 3 (three) months from the date of receipt of this order, in default he will suffer simple imprisonment for 15(fifteen) days. If the convict-appellant does not pay the remaining portion of the fine as ordered or opts to serve out the period of imprisonment in lieu of payment of fine, he is not exempted from paying the same. In that event, the Court concerned shall realise the fine under the provisions of Section 386 of the Cr.P.C.

In the result, the appeal is dismissed with modification of sentence and with directions made above. The convict-appellant is released from the bail bond.

Send down the Lower Court's records (LCR)(if any) at once.
Communicate the judgment and order to the Court concerned
forthwith.

(Mamnoon Rahman, J:)